

Color Harmony

Building color schemes that feel unified

Color harmony means that all the colors in a work feel like they belong together — they have a coherent relationship. There are classic color harmony schemes, but the underlying principle is always the same: unified color makes stronger art.

KEY CONCEPTS

Monochromatic

One hue, varied in saturation and value. The simplest harmony — virtually impossible to get wrong. Great for studying value without the complication of hue. Limited in emotional range but can be strikingly powerful.

Analogous

Colors that sit adjacent on the wheel: red, red-orange, orange. These create harmonious, naturalistic palettes. Common in landscape painting. Add a small complementary accent to break the monotony and create a focal point.

Triadic

Three colors equally spaced on the wheel (e.g., red, yellow, blue). Creates vibrant, dynamic palettes. Use one color dominantly (60%), one secondarily (30%), one as accent (10%).

Dominant Color Strategy

The most practical approach: choose one dominant color family (warm, cool, or neutral) and use the others as subordinates. All great paintings have a dominant color temperature. Fight for unity at every stage.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Paint the same scene in monochromatic, then analogous, then triadic. Compare.
2. Analyze 3 paintings you admire — identify their color harmony scheme.
3. Create a color palette for an imaginary scene using only analogous colors.

FURTHER READING

■ Ctrl+Paint – Color Harmony

<https://www.ctrlpaint.com/videos/color-harmony>

■ Proko – Color Schemes

<https://youtu.be/AZhO4VjQUPE>